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**Zuckerberg: AI increased
the time spent on
Facebook and Instagram
in Q2**

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg credited AI with driving up the time users spent on the company's apps in the second quarter. While consumers are increasingly complaining about the prevalence of "AI slop" — or low-quality AI-generated content flooding social apps — Meta says that AI systems are getting better at helping users connect with recommended content.

"AI is significantly improving our ability to show people content that they're going to find interesting and useful," Zuckerberg told investors on the [Q2](#) earnings call. "Advancements in our recommendation systems have improved quality so much that it has led to a 5% increase in time spent on Facebook and 6% on Instagram just this quarter."

Overall, Meta estimated that over 3.4 billion people used one of its "family of apps" — meaning Facebook, Instagram, Messenger, and/or WhatsApp — on a daily basis in June. That figure is up 6% year-over-year and helped drive the total family of apps revenue to \$47.1 billion, up 22% year-over-year.

The company additionally shared that video time spent increased 20% year-over-year in the quarter, also due to optimizations of Meta's ranking systems and its work to promote more original content on Instagram.

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Meta’s X competitor, Threads, was also seeing time spent gains due to the “incorporation of LLMs,” Meta noted.

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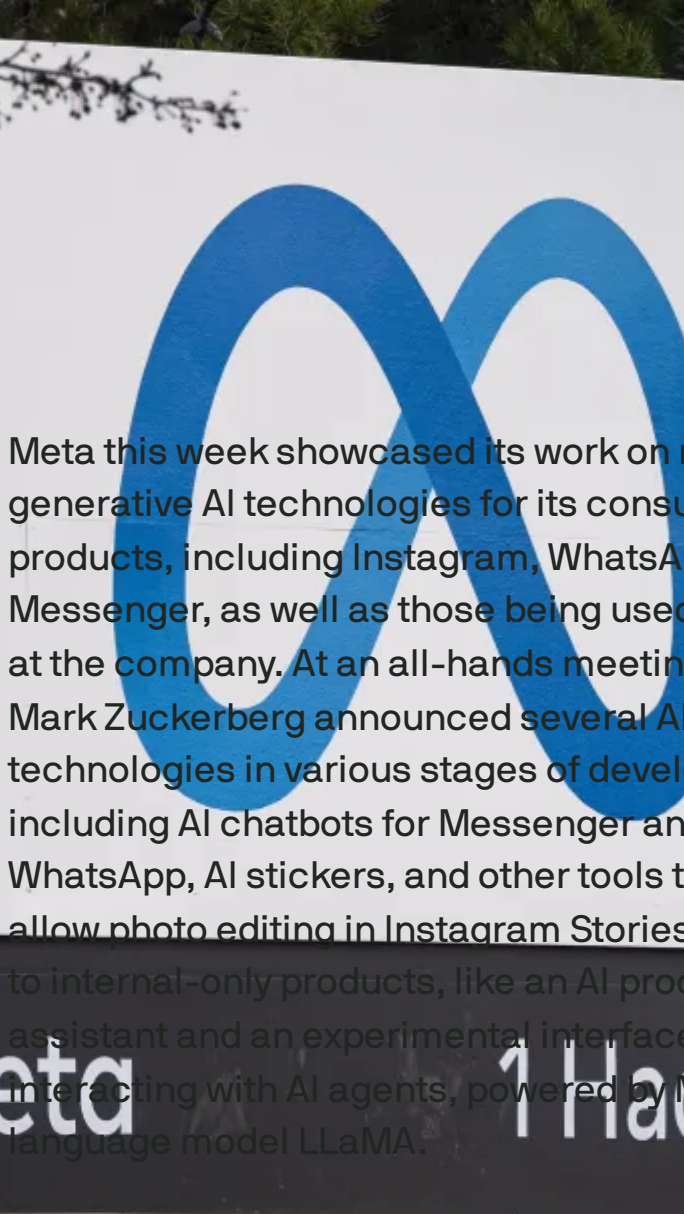
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KEEP READING

AI



Meta previews
generative AI tools
coming to WhatsApp,
Messenger and
Instagram, plus internal
AI tools



Meta this week showcased its work on new generative AI technologies for its consumer products, including Instagram, WhatsApp and Messenger, as well as those being used internally at the company. At an all-hands meeting, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced several AI technologies in various stages of development, including AI chatbots for Messenger and WhatsApp, AI stickers, and other tools that would allow photo editing in Instagram Stories, in addition to internal-only products, like an AI productivity assistant and an experimental interface for interacting with AI agents, powered by Meta's large language model LLaMA.

[Axios](#) had first reported the news of the consumer-facing AI agents and photo editing tools, specifically. But the larger presentation touched on a number of areas where Meta is developing AI technologies and commentary about where it sees this space going.

In addition, the company announced it's planning to host an internal AI hackathon in July focused on generative AI, which could result in new AI products that eventually make their way to Meta's users.

The news follows Zuckerberg's [statements during Meta's Q1 earnings](#) that it was exploring how to put new AI technologies to use in products that reach billions of users worldwide.

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During the call with investors, Zuckerberg had first teased Meta’s plans to explore “chat experiences” in WhatsApp and Messenger, as well as visual creation tools for posts on Facebook and Instagram, among other things. During the meeting, Zuckerberg shared more about these projects in a joint presentation with Ahmad Al-Dahle, VP of Engineering, Generative AI at Meta.

For instance, Meta’s AI chatbots, or AI agents as they’re being called, would allow consumers to interact with AIs that had unique personas and skill sets that could help and entertain people.

This is one of the areas in the consumer market that’s been gaining increasing attention and investment in recent months, as demand for AI chatbots has taken off. One leading app in this space, Character.AI, developed by researchers who helped build [LaMDA](#) (Language Model for Dialogue Applications) while at Google, [gained over 1.7 million new installs](#) in less than a week on the market, it said. The company is backed by [\\$150 million](#) in Series A funding, led by Andreessen Horowitz (a16z). However, the app competes with numerous other chatbot apps on the App Store providing similar functionality, ranging from those that allow users to develop their own AI characters, like Replika, to those that serve a particular purpose, like writing helpers or personal assistants.

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the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

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Meta plans to first release its AI agents on Messenger and WhatsApp but sees a broader future for such technologies that may see them expanding across its family of applications, and eventually to smart glasses, Zuckerberg told employees. In those cases, the vision is that consumers would wear some sort of smart glasses — similar to Meta’s Ray-Ban Stories — to interact with the agents via voice.

As one example, a user at an airport could ask the agent what to do in the city for a couple of hours during a layover. Users could also prompt the agent to respond to queries in specific styles, as you could with a text-based agent. While Ray-Ban Stories are sunglasses — and not likely appropriate for smart glasses with AI chat — Meta has been developing other tech in this space, like [Project Aria](#) and efforts from [its Research Lab](#).

In addition, Meta said in the meeting it was experimenting with AI that would allow users to engage with a text prompt in order to modify their own photos for sharing in Instagram Stories. This also comes on the heels of significant consumer interest in AI photo editors, including the viral trend of AI avatars that kicked off last year, [sending apps like Lensa AI](#) to the top of the App Store. Apps that turn [words into AI photos](#), like Wonder, are also popular across the App Store.



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In Meta’s case, the plan is to introduce AI stickers in Messenger, which could be generated from a text prompt. Another project, which has yet to enter internal testing, would allow users to type in a prompt as to how they want to edit a photo they’re planning to post to Instagram Stories.

For consumers, the benefit of Meta’s entry into this space is that these tools would be made free to use, thanks to Meta’s ad-supported business. Most competitive apps on the App Store offer only limited AI edits for free, but then push users into ongoing subscriptions to try all the features.

The meeting also showcased other ways Meta was using generative AI for internal purposes.

This included an experimental internal-only interface to an “agents playground” powered by its large language model LLaMA where Meta employees could have conversations with AI agents and then provide feedback to help the company improve its systems. It’s also working with MetaGen, which provides APIs for Meta’s text and image generation models for experimental use and prototyping, and Metamate, an internal productivity assistant that pulls information from internal sources to perform various tasks, driven by users’ text prompts.

For instance, developers could ask Metamate to help it find bugs in products they were dogfooding, while others could use it to help find space in their calendar by shifting meetings around.

Meta confirmed to TechCrunch its initial consumer-facing tools will arrive this year, likely sometime in

the next few months.

“In the last year, we’ve seen some really incredible breakthroughs — qualitative breakthroughs — on generative AI and that gives us the opportunity to now go take that technology, push it forward, and build it into every single one of our products,” Zuckerberg said during the presentation. “We’re going to play an important and unique role in the industry in bringing these capabilities to billions of people in new ways that other people aren’t going to do, he added.

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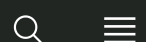
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IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

APPS



WhatsApp was down in Meta's second big outage this year

Sarah Perez — 12:31 PM PDT · April 3, 2024

For the second time in just over a month, Meta's apps, including WhatsApp, and to some extent, Messenger and Instagram, faced outages and intermittent issues. While it's rare for services as large as those operated by Meta to go down entirely, Meta's [status page detailed](#) disruptions to key business services, including its Ads Manager, Messenger Platform, WhatsApp Business API and others. WhatsApp also [confirmed](#) the outage in an update to its X account.

"We know some people are experiencing issues right now, we're working on getting things back to

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APPS



The Browser Company launches a \$20 monthly subscription for its AI-powered browser

Ivan Mehta - 19 minutes ago

100% for everyone as quickly as possible,” the company shared at 2:55 p.m. ET.

We know some people are experiencing issues right now, we're working on getting things back to 100% for everyone as quickly as possible

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— WhatsApp (@WhatsApp) [April 3, 2024](#)

Users also reported issues accessing Instagram and Messenger, according to social media posts and crowdsourced reporting sites like [Downdector](#). The latter, however, cannot serve as an official confirmation of an outage — only a signal that one could be underway. Press inquiries to Meta about the outages' cause were not returned.

The largest trouble seems to be with WhatsApp, though some people were seeing it resolved as of the time of writing.

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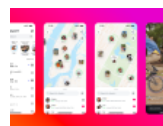
AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 12 hours ago

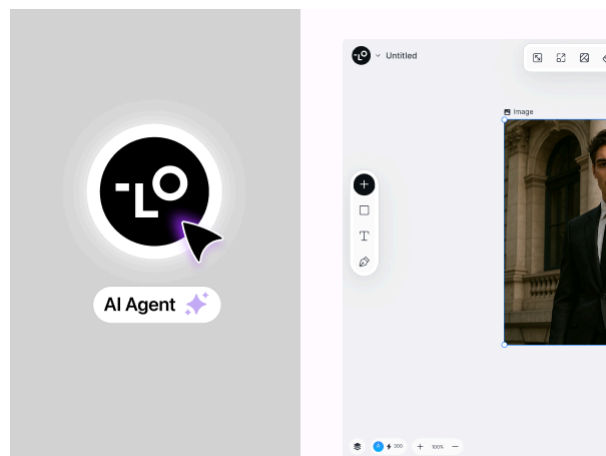
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Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 17 hours ago

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(In our own tests, Meta's apps were loading and we could send messages via WhatsApp, which indicates either the outages were not global in nature or they've already been fixed.)

Neither Messenger, Facebook or Instagram have publicly posted a confirmation of any issues via their X accounts.

This is not the first time Meta's apps have seen a sizable outage this year.

On [Super Tuesday in the U.S.](#) (March 5, 2024), Facebook, Instagram and Threads were all down, leading users to experience error messages that "something went wrong" or they were taken to a landing page where they were logged out and couldn't get back in. That outage lasted for a couple of hours before the apps came back online. At the time, Meta's status page had signaled problems with products like Ads Manager as well.

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Post updated after publication after the outage was resolved. According to WhatsApp, the issue was fixed by 6:19 pm ET, per [a post on their X account](#).

And we're back. Happy chatting!

— WhatsApp (@WhatsApp) [April 3, 2024](#)

Facebook, Instagram and Threads were all down in massive Meta outage on Super Tuesday



Reports are coming in that a number of Meta's top social apps, including Facebook, Instagram, and Threads, are all experiencing an outage on Tuesday morning.

When loading the apps or websites, users receive an error message that "something went wrong" and to try again later, or, in the case of Facebook, they're taken to a [Continue reading](#)

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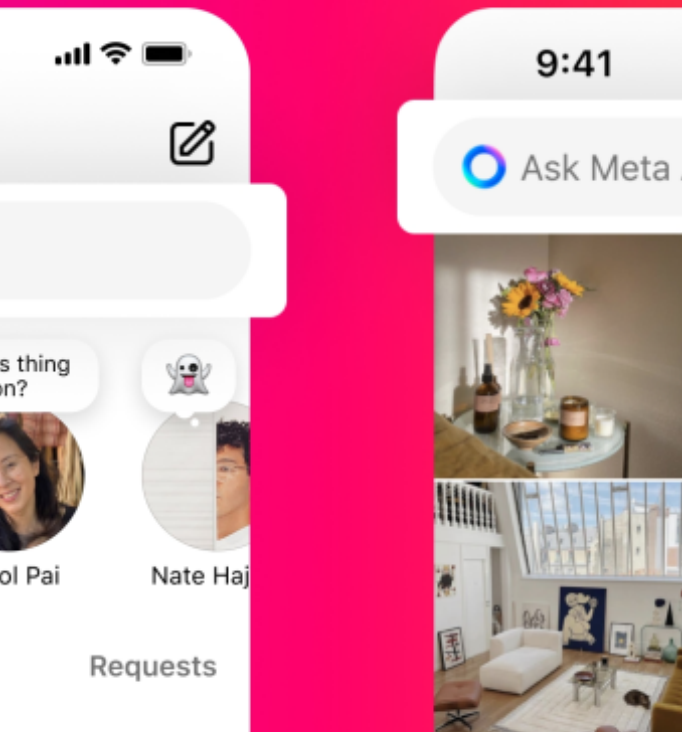
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Meta adds its AI chatbot, powered by Llama 3, to the search bar across its apps

Ivan Mehta — 9:00 AM PDT · April 18, 2024



Meta's making several big moves today to promote its AI services across its platform. The company has upgraded its AI chatbot with its newest large language model, Llama 3, and it is now running it in the search bar of its four major apps (Facebook, Messenger, Instagram and WhatsApp) across multiple countries. Alongside this, the company launched other new features, such as faster image generation and access to web search results.

This confirms and extends a test that TechCrunch reported on [last week](#), when we spotted that the company had started testing Meta AI on Instagram's search bar.

Additionally, the company is also launching a new [meta.ai](#) site for users to access the chatbot.

The news underscores Meta's efforts to stake out a position as a mover and shaker amid the current hype for generative AI tools among consumers. Chasing after other popular services in the market such as those from OpenAI, Mark Zuckerberg

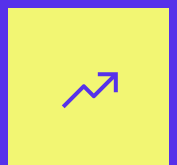
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claimed today that Meta AI is possibly the “most intelligent AI assistant that you can freely use.”

Meta first rolled out Meta AI in [the U.S. last year](#). It is now expanding the chatbot in the English language in over a dozen countries, including Australia, Canada, Ghana, Jamaica, Malawi, New Zealand, Nigeria, Pakistan, Singapore, South Africa, Uganda, Zambia and Zimbabwe.

The company last week started testing [Meta AI in countries like India and Nigeria](#), but notably, India was missing from today’s announcement. Meta said that it plans to keep Meta AI in test mode in the country at the moment.

“We continue to learn from our users tests in India. As we do with many of our AI products and features, we test them publicly in varying phases and in a limited capacity,” a company spokesperson said in a statement.

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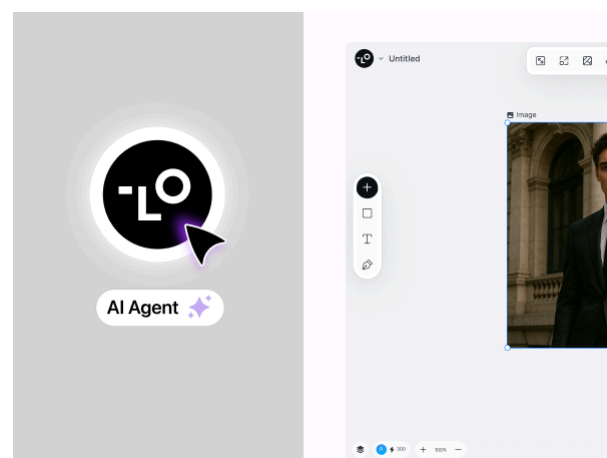
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New features

Users could already ask Meta AI for writing or recipe suggestions. Now, they can also ask for web-related results powered by Google and Bing.



IMAGE CREDITS: META

The company said that it is also making image generation faster. Plus, users can ask Meta AI to animate an image or turn an image into a GIF. Users can see the AI tool modifying the image in real time as they type. The company has also worked on making image quality of AI-generated photos better.



IMAGE CREDITS: META

AI-powered image-generation tools have been [bad at spelling out words](#). Meta claims that its new model has also shown improvements in this area.

Why is AI so bad at spelling? Because image generators aren't actually reading text



AI models are easily acing the SAT, defeating chess grandmasters and debugging code like it's nothing. But put an AI up against some middle schoolers at the spelling bee, and it'll get knocked

out faster than you can say diffusion. For all the advancements we've seen in AI, it still can't spell. If you ask

All AI things everywhere at once

Meta is adopting the approach of having Meta AI available in as many places as it can. It is making the bot available on the search bar, in individual and group chats and even in the feed.

The company said that you can ask questions related to posts in your Facebook feed. For example, if you see a photo of the aurora borealis, you could ask Meta AI for suggestions about what is the best time to visit Iceland to see northern lights.

IMAGE CREDITS: META

Meta AI is already available on the Ray-Ban smart glasses, and the company said that soon it will be available on the Meta Quest headset, too.

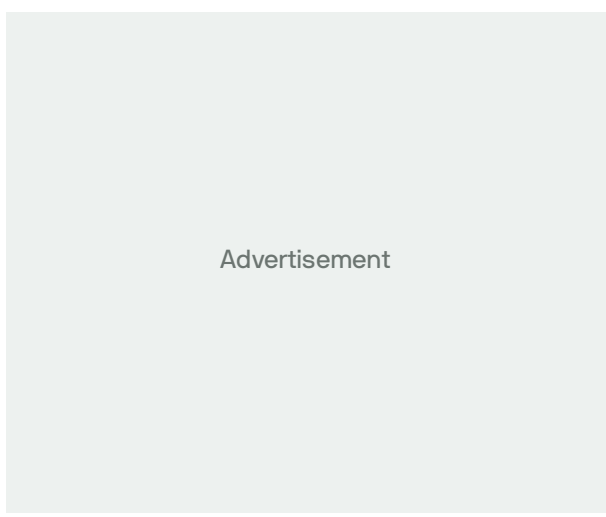
There are downsides to having AI in so many places. Specifically, the models can “hallucinate” and make up random, often non-sensical responses, so using them across multiple platforms could end up presenting a content moderation nightmare. Earlier this week, [404 Media](#) reported that Meta AI, chatting in a parents group, said that it had a gifted and academically challenged child who attended a particular school in New York. (Parents spotted the odd message, and Meta eventually also weighed in and removed the answer, saying that the company would continue to work on improving these systems.)

“We share information within the features themselves to help people understand that AI might

return inaccurate or inappropriate outputs. Since we launched, we’ve constantly released updates and improvements to our models, and we’re continuing to work on making them better,” Meta told 404 Media.

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Ivan Mehta

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